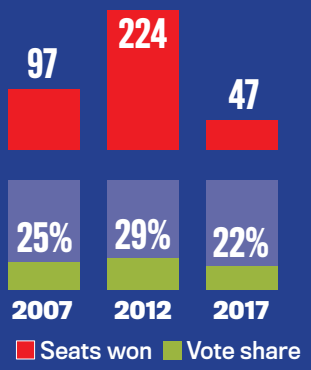
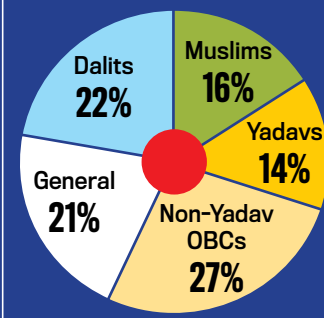
SP & FRIENDS

PREVIOUS ELECTIONS: SEATS & VOTES



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CRUCIAL ALLIES

Through alliances with the RLD, SBSP and PSP(L), the SP has given itself a strong footprint across Uttar Pradesh

RLD

The Rashtriya Lok Dal, led by Jayant Chaudhury, is a regional party that focuses mainly on Jats, who are classified as OBCs. They are a significant bloc in at least a dozen seats across western UP

SBSP

The Suheldev Bhartiya Samaj Party, led by Om Prakash Rajbhar, has a footprint mainly in Varanasi, Azamgarh, Ballia and Mau. Rajbhars are considered one of the more influential OBC communities in eastern UP

PSP(L)

The Pragatisheel Samaj Party (Lohia), led by Shivpal Yadav, has a presence across the state. The PSP(L) chief is popular among the Samajwadi Party's old loyalists, and can also rely on his cross-party connections

OTHER PARTNERS

The SP has also allied with smaller parties to tie up regional votes

MAHAN DAL

Influential in central UP, the party focuses on Mauryas and Shakyas—over four per cent of the population

JANWADI PARTY (SOCIALIST)

Influential in east UP, it focuses on the Nonia Chauhans, who make up two per cent of the population

APNA DAL (KAMERAWADI)

Influential in east UP, it focuses on Kurmis, who make up over seven per cent of the population of Uttar Pradesh

of the party, uniting warring factions and even suing for peace with his disgruntled uncle, Shivpal Yadav, who had left the party and formed his own unit. He also learnt from the defeat of the Grand Alliance he had put together with the BSP for the Lok Sabha election in 2019. Despite the alliance's seemingly infallible combined vote share of nearly 40 per cent, the BJP-led NDA won 64 of the 80 seats in the state. What hurt more was that the BSP won 10 seats and the SP took just 5. While Mayawati broke away from the alliance soon after the results, abusing the SP for the defeat, Akhilesh refused to engage in a *tu tu, main main* battle. Instead, he focused on charting a clear solo future that could challenge the formidable war machinery of the BJP. Far more mature than before, he is now seen to possess a mind of his own and is willing to take tough decisions and tell people off.

This time, he shunned the prospect of an alliance with even the Congress. His reason: "They were asking for too many seats and it didn't seem to benefit the SP to do a tie-up." Instead, he and his team studied the key reasons for his 2017 defeat. Among them, they zeroed in on one fact: from 2012 onwards, the BJP had worked hard to shed its image of being a party of the elite castes, particularly of Brahmins and Banias. To do that, it sharp-focused on a different part of UP's social geography: its vast OBC community map, which accounts for as much as 40 per cent of the state's overall votes. Ignoring the Yadavs, who account for only eight per cent of that total, the party built bridges and alliances with the expansive array of non-Yadavs. These included bits of everything on that whole graded scale from middle OBC castes to those that fell in the extreme backward class (EBC) classification, from Patels to Rajbhars, Mauryas, Kushwahas, Nishads and a host of others. Many of them may come with only around 2-3 per cent of the total vote, that too spread across major regions, but together they added up to a substantial number. Moreover, it was like taking a torch to an unlit part of the map: it made visible even darker hinterlands. This was the Dalit population, 20 per cent of UP, but broken up into 65 castes. Mayawati had a tight hold on the Jatavs, her own community, which constitutes a little over half of all Dalits in UP. So the BJP went about winning over the non-Jatavs: Pasi, Dhobi, Kori, Khatik, Basor, Sapera et al. The result? Post-poll analysis in 2017 showed that the BJP had won as much as 58 per cent of the OBC votes and 17 per cent of the Dalit votes, besides of course 62 per